

UNITY ON DISPLAY Congress and Left supporters in a rally against the Centre and the TMC government in Kolkata

Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar instead and also expressed her ambivalence about a Congress-organised opposition event. The Left Democratic Front (LDF) criticised the Congress as "immature" for not inviting Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan. However, two Left stalwarts—CPI(M) and CPI general secretaries Sitaram Yechury and D. Raja—were present at the Kanteerava Stadium.

In fact, even as the TMC, Aam Aadmi Party, Samajwadi Party, Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) and others were seen trying to cobble together a non-Congress third front to take on the BJP, the Left had been advocating for a single opposition of secular parties. Though both Yechury and Raja have held talks with various parties, they are votaries of a strong opposition inclusive of the Congress.

The one state where an alliance between the Left and the Congress has been playing out in interesting ways in recent years has been West Bengal.

Once bitter foes, they united to take on the TMC in the 2016 assembly polls. The results were disastrous for the Left—it won 33 out of the state's 294 seats with a vote share of 19.75 per cent—a sheer drop of 10.35 percentage points. The Congress won 44 seats. The Left and Congress along with the Indian Secular Front (ISF) fought the 2021 polls as the Samyukta Morcha. The Congress-Left vote share plummeted by 15 percentage points and both drew a blank in the assembly. The alliance fought in the Tripura assembly polls in 2023, securing 14 seats with a reduced vote share. In March 2023, the assembly bypoll for the Muslim-dominated Sagardighi constituency in Murshidabad district saw the first significant success of the alliance.

The bypoll, where the Left-backed Congress candidate Byron Biswas defeated the TMC candidate by over 22,000 votes, was an eye-opener, especially because it laid bare Muslim disaffection with the TMC. Muslims make up 27 per cent of Bengal's population, and on their support depends much of the TMC's political heft. The Sagardighi alliance is now a model not for just taking the alliance forward, but for giving the electorate, especially minority voters, a secular platform—an alternative to the TMC's raising the BJP bugaboo to garner minority votes.

MINORITY DISAFFECTION WITH THE TMC IS REFLECTED IN SUPPORT FOR THE LEFT AND CONGRESS

Post Sagardighi, the Left-Congress combination is becoming a force to reckon with, particularly in districts like North Dinajpur, Malda, Murshidabad and South 24 Parganas, where the minority population hovers between 50 per cent and 66 per cent. Says veteran Congress leader Abdul Mannan, "Why do you think Muslims are gravitating towards us? It's everything but religion. Who got killed in the Bagtui massacre? Who are killed in bomb explosions at Khadikul in East Midnapore? Muslims realise that the ruling party is using them, only to leave them to die."

CPI(M) state general secretary Mohd Salim says that Muslims feel disrespected for being treated as a vote bank. "People working in the unorganised sector and small businessmen have suffered the most because of the parallel economy being run at the behest of ruling party and its criminal nexus. Besides, poor Muslims are victims of the BJP-TMC tussle, resulting in the stoppage of MGNREGA work," he alleges.

How does the Left-Congress alliance react to Mamata's recent proposal that strong regional parties take on the BJP in their home turfs, while they in turn support the Congress in the 200 Lok Sabha seats where they are in direct contest with the ruling party? Mannan recalls, "Soniaji once told me that the Left is dependable, but not TMC. Moreover, who's Mamata to tell us how many seats the Congress will fight?" Pradesh Congress president Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury says, "Mamata Banerjee visited Bihar and UP to support those fighting the BJP. Why did not she visit Karnataka to support the Congress?"

Chowdhury says Mamata is looking for an understanding with the Congress because she is getting cornered in her own state. The reason for her panic is elemental—shifting of minority votes. As per CSDS Lok Niti data, 75 per cent minorities voted Trinamool in the 2021 assembly polls in the face of the BJP's aggressive Hindutva campaign. With the BJP still not able to put its house in order in Bengal, minorities are looking for a secular sanctuary. ■